



A Short Guide to Hosting Safe Virtual Meetings



Safe
Online
by CchUB



Co-Creation Hub

The Covid-19 pandemic and the resultant lockdowns across several countries of the world has seen a rise in the use of web conferencing software.

Now more than ever, internet safety is paramount. Unfortunately, the rise in virtual meetings has also seen more meetings being disrupted by distasteful elements. It is evident from the multiple reports of video meetings being disrupted by pornographic/hateful images and threatening language.

Most Virtual Meeting services have built-in security features, and many providers will give you some basic security suggestions.

Regardless of the platform, here are a few simple tips for hosting a secure virtual meeting:



Know The Platform

Video conferencing platforms have inbuilt security settings to prevent security incidents. As such, it is important that users of video conferencing platforms read the 'How-to-Use' guide or go to the 'Help' section of these platforms before full adoption for use.



Use The 'Waiting Room' Feature in Video Conferencing Softwares

Turning on this feature puts participants in a separate virtual room before the meeting and allows the host to admit only people who are supposed to be in the room.



Make Sure Password Protection is Enabled on Meetings

Platforms, like Zoom, auto-generate a password in addition to a meeting room ID. Make sure that your service uses both a meeting ID number and a password or PIN. If the service lets you create a password for the meeting, use password creation best practices — like using a random string of numbers, letters, and symbols. Do not create easy passwords like "123456."



Do not Share Links to Virtual Meetings on Social Media

While sharing the link to join a virtual event on social media may seem like the convenient thing to do, it exposes the event to people who might want to create mischief. The best practice is to invite attendees through a registration form, then share the link to the registered set of email addresses.



Disable Audio, Video & Screen Sharing by Default

A vital feature to look out for on a video conferencing software is a setting that allows hosts to manage the audio and screen-sharing feature. Once a meeting has begun, this feature enables the host to set their screen, video and audio sharing options to "Host-Only" or to allow specific participant(s) share their audio, video and screen when appropriate. Equally, as a participant on a virtual call, it is best practice to turn off your camera, mute your device's microphone and be sure you are not screen-sharing, by default, in your settings before joining the call.



When Using the Video Option Make Sure the Background is Clear of Identifiable Information

It is best to turn off your webcam as a participant and listen-in via audio. However if your video needs to be on, make sure you have a plain background with no personal identifiable material. This prevents possible social engineering efforts to learn about you through the background objects in your video feed.



Use the Latest Versions of the Web Conferencing Software

Security vulnerabilities are likely to be exploited more often on older software versions.

For instance, Zoom recently updated its software to require password-protected meetings, and it has paused work on new features to focus its developers on resolving privacy and security vulnerabilities, which indicates that there will be more updates to come on the platform. Double-check that as either a host or a participant, you are using the most up-to-date version available.



Learn How to Use the Eject Button

When an intruder manages to enter into a call or if one of the participants becomes unruly, the 'Waiting Room' feature when enabled allows the host to put participants back in the waiting room.

Most video conferencing software also have an 'Eject' or 'Remove' button that can be used to drop people off the call. The 'Eject' or 'Remove' button prevents an intruder from rejoining automatically without authentication approval from the host.



Use the Lock Meeting Function for Important Meetings

Another vital feature to look out for on a video conferencing software is the 'Lock Meeting' feature.

Once all the specified participants have joined the call, then turning on this feature allows the host to lock the meeting thereby preventing anyone else from joining with permission.

Enabling this feature can also protect the meeting from intruders. If a valid participant drops out, be sure to unlock the meeting to let them back in and then re-lock after they return.



Let Participants Know When They are Being Recorded

If you need to record a meeting, make sure all participants know that they are being recorded. The software used will usually indicate when a session is being recorded, but it's good practice to inform participants before the meeting starts.

Here is a review of some of the most popular apps to help you make smart decisions on virtual meetings

Security and Privacy Review of Top Video Conferencing Platforms

Platform	Encryption (regular)	End-to-End Encryption (Advanced)	Security & Updates	Strong Password Requirement And Two-FA Feature	Vulnerability Management	Privacy Policy (not generic but specific to the service)
Zoom	Yes	No	Yes (Regularly)	Yes	Poor	Yes https://zoom.us/privacy
Google Duo Google Hangout Google Meet	Yes	No (only Google Duo has)	Yes (Regularly)	Yes	Consistent	Yes https://policies.google.com
Skype	Yes	Yes (users have to turn it on)	Yes (Not regularly)	Yes	Poor	Yes https://go.skype.com/privacy
GoToMeeting	Yes	Yes	Yes (Regularly)	Yes	Consistent	Yes https://www.logmeininc.com/legal/privacy
Microsoft Teams	Yes	No	Yes (Regularly)	Yes	Consistent	Yes https://privacy.microsoft.com/en-us/privacystatement
Cisco Webex	Yes	Yes	Yes (Regularly)	Yes	Consistent	Yes https://www.cisco.com/c/en/us/about/legal/privacy-full.html

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